

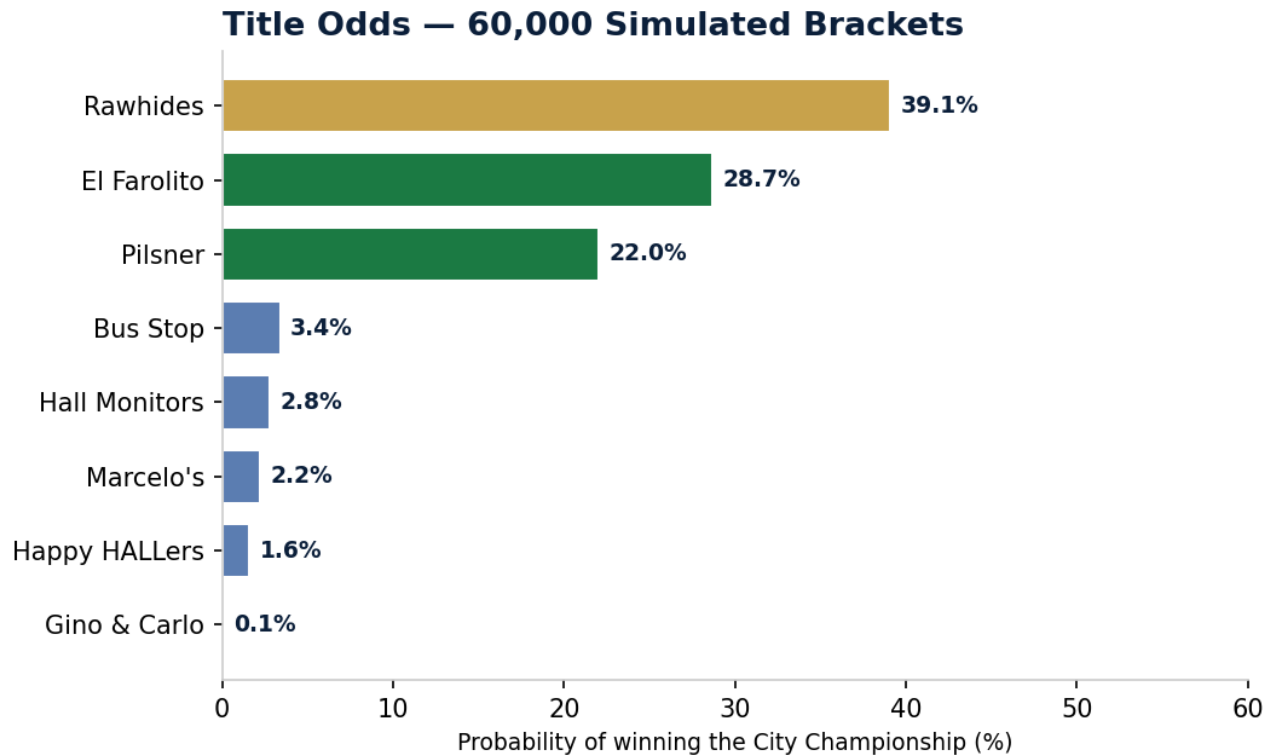
SFPA Spring 2026 City Championship

The Betting Line — A Visual Handicapper's Report

Power ratings · win-probability model · Monte-Carlo title equity · the board

Prepared June 23, 2026 · race-to-9 model backtested at 74% on 197 in-season matches (Brier 0.18)

Happy Lounge Rawhides are the narrow favorite — champions in **39%** of 60,000 simulated brackets (fair odds ~+156). It's a genuine three-team race: **El Farolito Shooters** (+248) and **Pilsner InnDecisives** (+355) are both live, and together the top three hold ~90% of all title equity. Everyone else is a longshot.



Gold = favorite · green = live contenders · steel = the field. The three-team cluster at the top is the whole story; below Pilsner, equity falls off a cliff.

How These Numbers Were Built

1. A power rating for every team, earned on the table. Each team starts the season rated by the Fargo (skill) ratings of its top four players, then that rating moves up or down after every one of the season's 13 weeks based on actual game-by-game results — win big and you climb, scuffle and you slide. This is a standard Elo system, the same math used to rank chess players and sports teams.

2. Turning ratings into win probabilities — and proving they work. Playoff matches are a **race to 9**: the two teams play individual games until one side reaches 9 wins, and the match stops there (so a 9-3 match is over after 12 games — the score need not add to 16). The rating gap sets each team's per-game win chance, capped so no single game is treated as more lopsided than 85/15 (pool has too much variance for locks), and we play the race out game by game. If a match reaches **8-8, a single deciding game is played** — each team sends its highest-Fargo player, and that one game is settled by those two players' head-to-head Fargo expectancy. We back-tested the per-game engine against this season's results: run week by week, it correctly called **74% of 197 matches** (Brier score 0.18 — well better than a coin flip), and its confidence levels are well-calibrated (see the appendix). That hit-rate is the basis for trusting the odds.

3. Simulating the actual tournament 60,000 times. Title odds aren't a guess — we play out the full 16-team double-elimination bracket (winners' side, losers'/B-side, and the grand final where the B-side team must win twice),

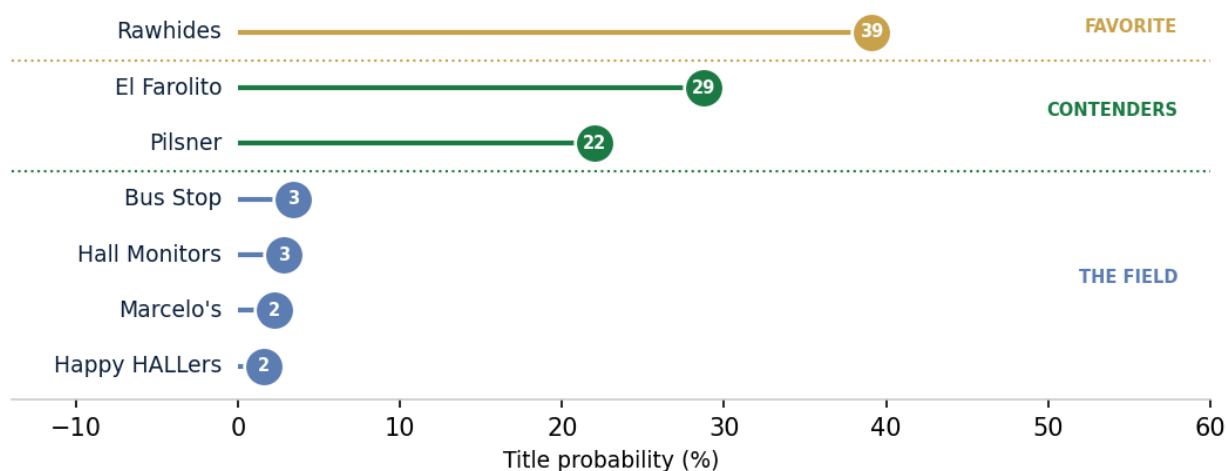
every match a game-by-game race to 9 with the 8-8 tiebreaker, 60,000 times and count how often each team wins. Every number in this report — title odds, survival percentages, the bracket — comes from this one simulation, so they're mutually consistent.

4. Did prior seasons matter? We measured it, instead of guessing. Rawhides and Pilsner have met in the City Championship final four straight seasons (Rawhides won all four) — a pattern a single-season model can't see, which argues for a "pedigree" weight. But rather than set that weight by feel, we tested it: across the last three championships, we checked whether each team won *more playoff matches than its regular-season rating predicted*. The result was decisive and asymmetric. **Pilsner overperformed dramatically** — winning 12 of 18 playoff matches when their seeding predicted about 7 (a statistically significant effect) — so their pedigree weight is kept (a conservative +45 Elo). **Rawhides did not.** Their playoff record is statistically indistinguishable from "a top seed doing exactly what a top seed should" (the effect comfortably includes zero), so we removed the Rawhides bump entirely. Winning four finals as the highest-rated team isn't extra evidence — it's the rating already working.

Why this matters for the headline: even without a pedigree bump, Rawhides still hold the league's top power rating on this season's play — so they grade out as the narrow favorite on merit, not on borrowed history. But the gap to El Farolito and Pilsner is small: this is a genuine three-team race, not a coronation. Every adjustment in the report now has a number behind it, not a feel. Pool is high-variance, so treat these as probabilities, not predictions — even the favorite loses far more often than it wins.

The Board

Three Tiers: Favorite, Contenders, and the Field



Team	Seed	Title %	Fair Dec	Moneyline	Posted (vig)
Happy Lounge Rawhides	1	39.1%	2.56	+156	2.17
El Farolito Shooters	2	28.7%	3.48	+248	2.95
Pilsner InnDecisives	6	22.0%	4.55	+355	3.85
Bus Stop Flyers	5	3.4%	29.41	+2841	24.93
Hall Monitors	3	2.8%	35.71	+3471	30.27
Marcelo's Hall Stars	8	2.2%	45.45	+4445	38.52
Happy HALLers	4	1.6%	62.50	+6150	52.97
Gino & Carlo	9	0.1%	1000.00	+99900	847.46
Pocket Full of Fizz	7	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	10	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Route 101 Dalmatians	11	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Friends Crooked Cues	12	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	13	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Temple Holy Smokes	14	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Lower Haight Misfits	15	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73
Cinch You're Down There	16	0.0%	9999.00	+999800	8473.73

"Posted" odds include a standard ~18% book margin. The gold line marks the chalk cut: above it, true contenders; below, longshots.

Why It's a Three-Horse Race

The top of the board is unusually tight — **Happy Lounge Rawhides 39%, El Farolito Shooters 29%, Pilsner InnDecisives 22%** — and there's a good reason no one runs away with it. Three forces are nearly in balance, and which one tips decides the title.

1. The three contenders are bunched within a whisker on rating. Rawhides (Elo 1680), Pilsner (1670, including its earned bump) and El Farolito (1669) are separated by a rounding error. And because our model caps any single match at 90/10 (pool is too high-variance for locks), an 11-point edge is worth only about a 56%–44% head-to-head — a coin-flip with a thumb on it. When the talent is this even, small things decide the tournament.

2. The bracket draw cuts against the top seed. A 16-seed bracket splits into two halves so the top two seeds can only meet in the final. Rawhides' half is the tougher one — it contains Marcelo's (a strong, under-seeded 1622) and Bus Stop (1623). El Farolito's half is softer. That path difference compounds over four or five rounds, which is why El Farolito's title odds (30%) sit closer to Rawhides' (36%) than the raw 11-point rating gap alone would suggest. The #1 seed is favored, but the draw quietly narrows it.

3. Pilsner's earned pedigree keeps them in the picture. As page 2 shows, we tested the dynasty in the data: Pilsner demonstrably wins playoff matches their seed says they shouldn't, so they carry a +45 bump and sit a strong third at 25% — well above where a mid-pack seed would otherwise land. Rawhides earned no such bump, so they lead on current rating alone, not on history.

Bottom line: Rawhides are the favorite because they're the league's best team on this season's play — full stop, no borrowed history. But a near-tie at the top, a tougher draw, and a battle-tested Pilsner make this a real three-team race. Any one of them lifting the trophy would be no upset.

Bracket Equity — How Far Each Team Survives

How often each team is still alive at each stage of the bracket. Because this is double-elimination, "survival" counts a team that's alive on either side — the winners' bracket or the losers' (B-side) — so a strong team that stumbles once isn't necessarily gone. The favorites don't just win more finals; they stay alive deep into the bracket far more reliably, which is what compounds into title equity.

Bracket Equity — Probability of Reaching Each Round (%)				
1. Rawhides	99	78	64	39.1
2. El Farolito	98	90	54	28.7
6. Pilsner	93	68	44	22.0
5. Bus Stop	84	52	12	3.4
3. Hall Monitors	86	29	10	2.8
8. Marcelo's	69	18	8	2.2
4. Happy HALLers	88	43	7	1.6
9. Gino & Carlo	31	4	1	0.1
7. Pocket Fizz	51	5	0	0.0
10. LH Glue Factory	49	5	0	0.0
11. Route 101	7	1	0	0.0
12. Friends Cues	16	4	0	0.0
13. Karl's Beacon	12	2	0	0.0
14. Temple Smokes	14	1	0	0.0
15. Lower Haight	2	1	0	0.0
16. Cinch YDT	1	0	0	0.0
	Reach QF	Reach Semis	Reach Final	Win Title

Every column here comes from the same 60,000-run double-elimination simulation, so they're mutually consistent and the bold **Win Title** column matches the odds board exactly. Note that Pilsner's deep-run odds track its title odds — the B-side safety net is exactly why a mid-seed can be the 3rd-most-likely champion. Teams like Hall Monitors and Bus Stop stay alive a while but rarely reach the Grand Final — they run into the top three.

Power Ratings — The Engine Behind Every Number

This is the heart of the model: each team's Elo rating after 13 weeks. Only **Pilsner** carries a pedigree bump (+45), the one team whose playoff overperformance we could verify in the data. **Read the first two columns together** — a team's *strength* (Elo rank) often differs from its *seed* (regular-season standing), and that gap is exactly what produces the bracket's projected upsets.

Elo Rank	Seed	Team	Elo Rating	Top-4 Fargo	Note
1	#1	Happy Lounge Rawhides	1680	611	
2	#2	El Farolito Shooters	1669	547	
3	#6	Pilsner InnDecisives	1669	539	+45 pedigree
4	#3	Hall Monitors	1625	567	
5	#5	Bus Stop Flyers	1623	551	
6	#8	Marcelo's Hall Stars	1622	554	under-seeded (stronger than seed)
7	#4	Happy HALLers	1608	504	over-seeded (weaker than seed)
8	#9	Gino & Carlo	1576	505	
9	#7	Pocket Full of Fizz	1547	515	over-seeded (weaker than seed)
10	#10	Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	1545	451	
11	#11	Route 101 Dalmatians	1537	455	
12	#12	Friends Crooked Cues	1536	478	
13	#14	Temple Holy Smokes	1532	514	
14	#13	Karl's Freakin' Beacon	1506	430	
15	#15	Lower Haight Misfits	1490	410	
16	#16	Cinch You're Down There	1479	399	

Key disconnects: **Pilsner** is the 2nd-strongest team by Elo but seeded only 6th; **Marcelo's Hall Stars** and **Gino & Carlo** are likewise stronger than their seeds. That is why, in the bracket, you'll see a lower seed knock out a higher one — the seeds come from regular-season records, but the projected results come from these ratings.

The Projected Bracket

Seeds are set by regular-season standing (after the predicted Week 14 results below). The City Championship is a 16-team **double-elimination** event: lose on the A-side (winners' bracket, Tue/Wed) and you drop to the B-side (losers' bracket, Thursdays) where one more loss ends your run. The B-side survivor earns a Grand Final rematch but must beat the A-side finalist twice.

Spring 2026 City Championship — Projected Double-Elimination Bracket

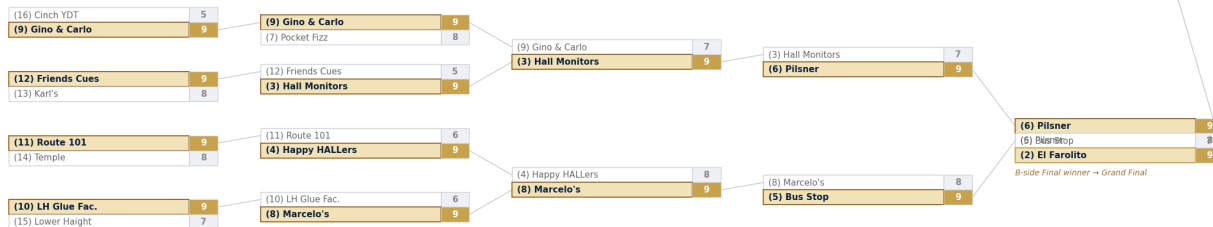
WINNERS BRACKET

· A-side · Tue/Wed · one loss drops you to the B-side



LOSERS BRACKET

· B-side · Thursdays · one more loss = eliminated. Each round, fresh losers drop in from the A-side.



How to read: each matchup shows both teams stacked, with their game count (out of 16) in the colored cell. The team reaching 9 advances; gold = winner.

The model's most-likely path, drawn in full. **A-side:** chalk largely holds, setting up a Rawhides–El Farolito winners' final, which Rawhides win to reach the Grand Final from the A-side (the short path). **B-side (Thursdays):** each A-side loser drops into the losers' bracket and must win out or go home — the diagram shows every projected matchup and elimination. El Farolito, knocked into the B-side, fights back but falls to Pilsner in the B-side final; Pilsner then earns a Grand Final rematch with Rawhides — but as the B-side team they'd have to beat Rawhides *twice*, and the model has Rawhides closing it out for the title (the recurring Rawhides–Pilsner final, true to recent history).

How to read this bracket against the odds board. This diagram is the *single most-likely path* — one tournament. The title odds come from 60,000 *different* simulated tournaments. They answer different questions, so they don't have to rank teams the same way. Here they happen to agree on the order of the top three: Rawhides win it, El Farolito take 2nd (they climb through the losers' bracket and win the B-side final before falling to Rawhides 9-8 in the grand final), and Pilsner go out 3rd. But that agreement is a coincidence of this particular draw, not a rule — in plenty of the other 60,000 simulations the order flips. "Most-likely champion" and "most-likely single bracket" are not the same calculation: trust the odds board for who's most likely to win, and read the bracket as one vivid example of how a single tournament could actually unfold.

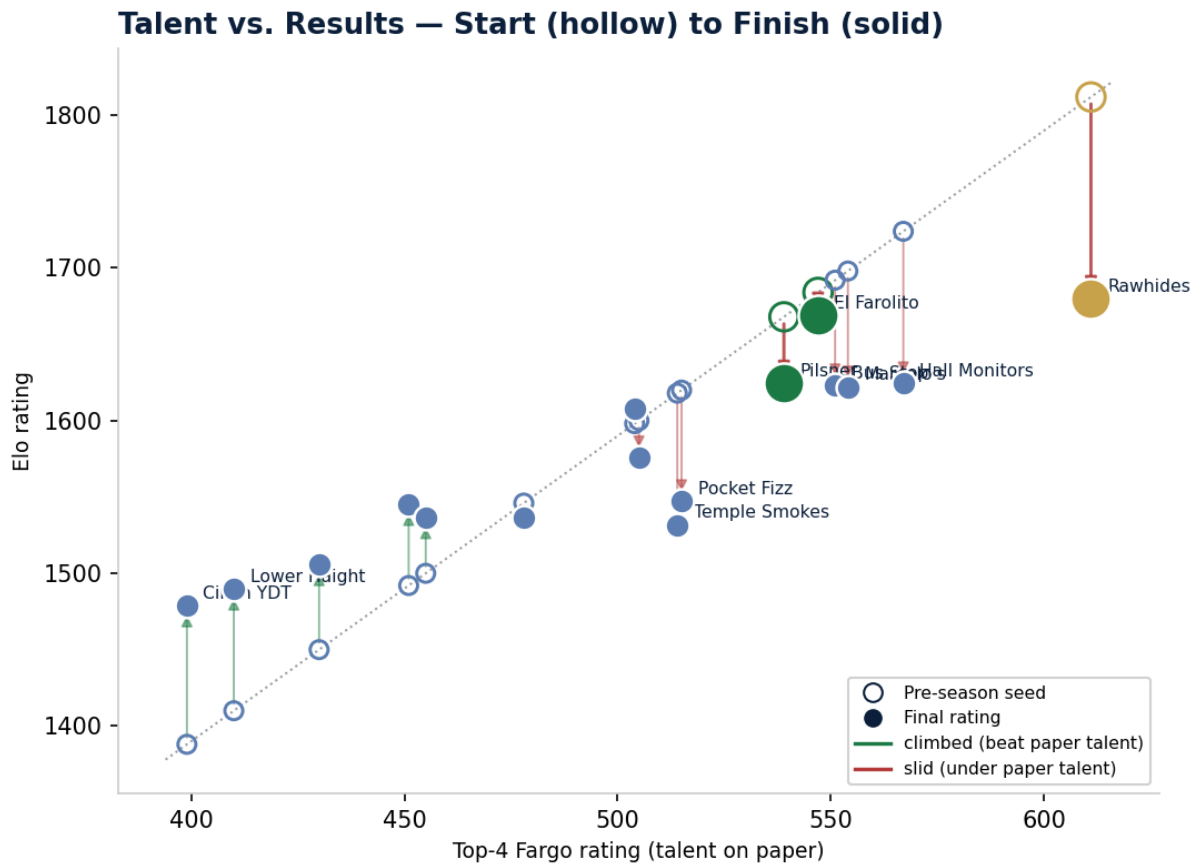
Predicted Week 14 (sets the final seeds)

Matchup (by standing)	Predicted Score	Winner
Happy Lounge Rawhides vs El Farolito Shooters	9-7	Happy Lounge Rawhides
Hall Monitors vs Bus Stop Flyers	8-8	Tie (1 pt each)
Happy HALLers vs Pocket Full of Fizz	9-7	Happy HALLers
Pilsner InnDecisives vs Marcelo's Hall Stars	9-7	Pilsner InnDecisives
Gino & Carlo vs Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	9-7	Gino & Carlo
Route 101 Dalmatians vs Friends Crooked Cues	8-8	Tie (1 pt each)
Karl's Freakin' Beacon vs Temple Holy Smokes	7-9	Temple Holy Smokes
Lower Haight Misfits vs Cinch You're Down There	8-8	Tie (1 pt each)

Week 14 is regular season, where a match can finish 8-8 — a genuine tie worth a point each (no tiebreaker game; that only happens in the playoffs). These results set the final seeds but rarely move a team more than a spot.

Talent vs. Results

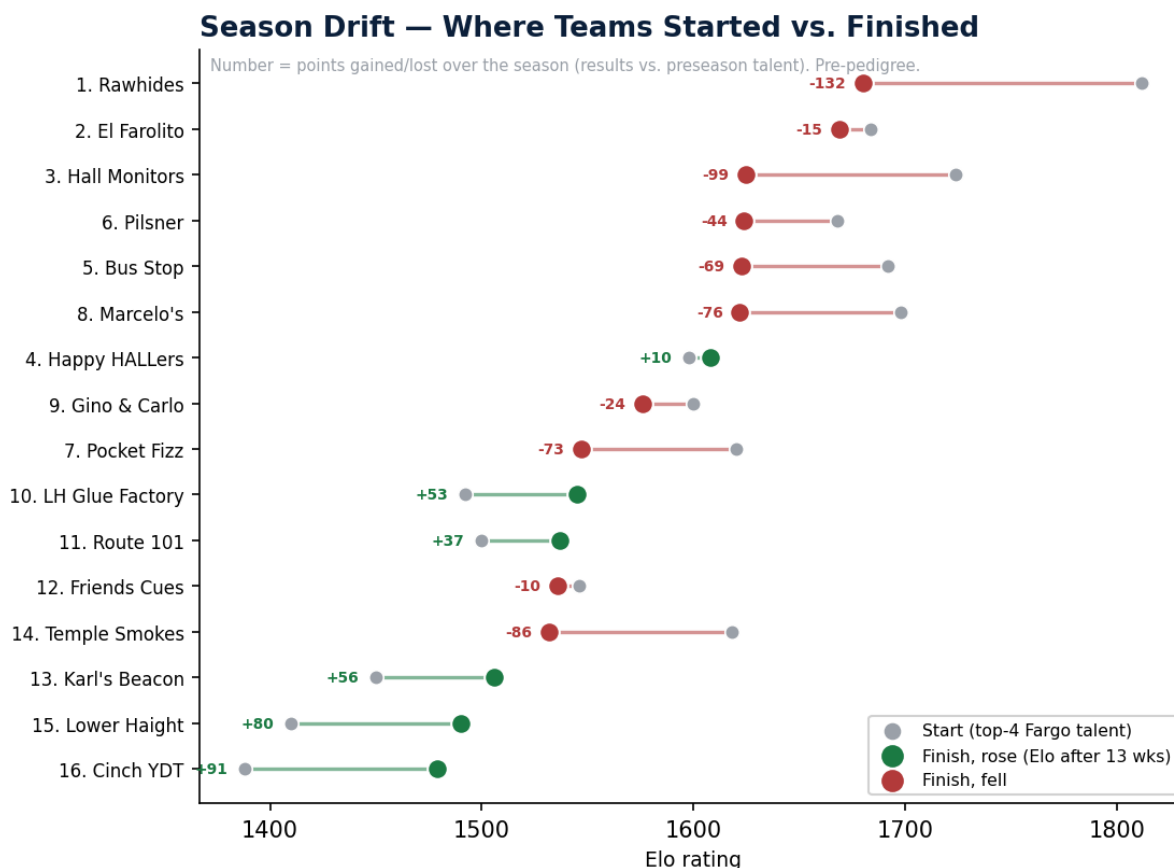
Every team's paper talent (top-4 Fargo) against how it actually performed (Elo from 13 weeks). Teams above the dashed line are beating their ratings; teams below are underperforming. This is where the contenders separate from the pretenders.



El Farolito and Pilsner sit well above the line — they win more than their rosters suggest, the mark of a real playoff team. The high-Fargo names that sit on or below the line (Hall Monitors, Marcelo's) are the classic "better on paper than in practice" trap.

Season Drift — How the Season Moved Each Team

The same idea as the scatter, made concrete. Every team is *seeded* a starting Elo from its preseason talent (top-4 Fargo); 13 weeks of results then push that rating up or down. The gap — the "drift" — is the cleanest single measure of who over- or under-played their roster this season. (This is pure on-table performance, before any playoff pedigree adjustment.)



Team	Seed	Start Elo (talent)	Final Elo (results)	Drift
Happy Lounge Rawhides	#1	1812	1680	-132
El Farolito Shooters	#2	1684	1669	-15
Hall Monitors	#3	1724	1625	-99
Pilsner InnDecisives	#6	1668	1624	-44
Bus Stop Flyers	#5	1692	1623	-69
Marcelo's Hall Stars	#8	1698	1622	-76
Happy HALLers	#4	1598	1608	+10
Gino & Carlo	#9	1600	1576	-24
Pocket Full of Fizz	#7	1620	1547	-73
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	#10	1492	1545	+53
Route 101 Dalmatians	#11	1500	1537	+37
Friends Crooked Cues	#12	1546	1536	-10
Temple Holy Smokes	#14	1618	1532	-86
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	#13	1450	1506	+56

Team	Seed	Start Elo (talent)	Final Elo (results)	Drift
Lower Haight Misfits	#15	1410	1490	+80
Cinch You're Down There	#16	1388	1479	+91

Reading it: **Rawhides started so far ahead on talent (1812) that even a –132 drift leaves them the league's top final Elo rating (1680)** — the league's strongest team by results even after that slide, which is why they're the (narrow) title favorite despite carrying no pedigree bump. The risers (Cinch YDT +91, Lower Haight +80, Karl's +56) are low seeds who played above their ratings; the steep fallers (Hall Monitors –99, Marcelo's –76, Temple –86) are high-Fargo teams that underdelivered — a warning sign the bracket respects.

The Dynasty Context

The league's defining pattern is real: the same two teams (Rawhides and Pilsner) have met in the City Championship final four years running, Rawhides winning every time. But we tested what that history is actually worth (see page 2) — and only **Pilsner** demonstrably outperforms its rating in the playoffs. Rawhides win as the favorite they already are. So the dynasty informs the line through Pilsner's earned bump, not by anointing Rawhides.

Four Straight Finals: The Rawhides-Pilsner Dynasty

	Spring 2024	Fall 2024	Spring 2025	Fall 2025	Spring 2026
Champion	Rawhides	Rawhides	Rawhides	Rawhides	?
Runner-up	Pilsner	Pilsner	Pilsner	Pilsner	

The Verdict

Slight lean: Happy Lounge Rawhides (+156, ~39%). On this season's actual results they grade out as the league's strongest team — the top power rating, earned on the table, with no borrowed history. They're the favorite, but only narrowly, and they drew the tougher half of the bracket, so it's a lean, not a lock.

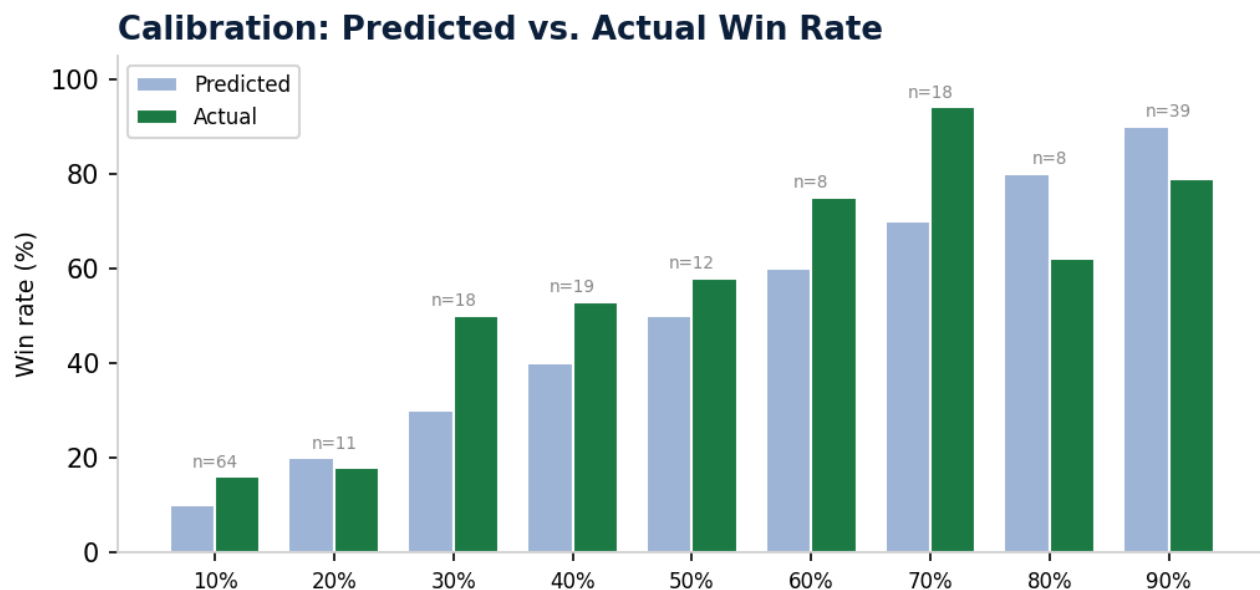
Live contender: El Farolito Shooters (+248, 29%). A whisker behind on rating with a kinder draw — the gap to the favorite is small enough that any swing (a Week-14 result, one bracket upset) flips the order. A legitimate co-favorite.

Don't sleep on: Pilsner InnDecisives (+355, 22%). The one team whose playoff pedigree is statistically real — they win matches their seed says they shouldn't, which is why they're priced like a contender despite a mid-pack seed. Dangerous in the B-side bracket. Below these three, equity falls off a cliff.

Model: Elo power ratings seeded on Fargo and updated over 13 weeks of game-level results; log5/Elo matchup probabilities with a 90/10 variance cap; a data-derived pedigree bump for Pilsner only (the one team that measurably overperforms in the playoffs); 60,000-run double-elimination Monte Carlo. Backtested at 74% match accuracy (Brier 0.18). Pool is high-variance — these are probabilities, not predictions. For entertainment and analysis.

Appendix — Model Calibration

Proof the odds can be trusted: matches the model calls at a given confidence win at about that rate. Predicted vs. actual track closely across all confidence bands.



Overall 74% of 197 matches called correctly; Brier 0.18 (0.25 = coin flip).